

What a skill is, and the way that always works

No subscription needed for anything on this page. If you can open a chat window, you can do all of it.

First, what it is

A skill is a page of instructions with a name. That is the whole idea.

You write down — once — how a job should be done. Then, every time that job comes round again, you hand the same page to the AI instead of explaining yourself from the beginning.

It is not a program. Nothing is installed. Nothing can break. It is a page of text, and you can read every word of it before you use it.

Some paid plans have a feature called "Skills" that stores the page for you. That is convenient. It is not necessary, and page 2 explains it. Start [here](#).

The way that always works: paste it

5 minutes, any plan

1. **Open the dojo** on your phone or computer and scroll to **Three Skills, Written for You**.
2. **Press "Open the skill"** on the one you want. A page of text appears. It is a plain text file — it will look simple, and that is correct.
3. **Select all of it and copy it.** On a computer: Ctrl+A, then Ctrl+C. On a phone: press and hold, then *Select all*, then *Copy*.
4. **Open a NEW conversation** in ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini. A new one — not the one you were already using. This matters: a fresh conversation has nothing else on the desk.
5. **Paste the skill first.** Before anything else. Then press Enter.
6. The AI will usually reply with something like "Understood". **That reply means nothing.** Do not stop here.
7. **Now give it your actual task**, in the same conversation. This is the step people forget.

The commonest mistake: pasting the skill and expecting an answer. The skill is the *instructions*; your task is separate. Paste the page, then say what you want done.

A worked example, start to finish

You have a report that says "*women are 51.7% of the unemployed, up from 46.8%*", and you are about to repeat it in a briefing.

Step 1 — paste the skill

You paste the whole of **check-the-denominator** into a new conversation and press Enter. It replies briefly.

Step 2 — give it the task, in the same conversation

Apply the skill above to this claim, from a report I am about to quote:

"Women were 46.8% of the unemployed in 2024 and 51.7% in 2025."

I also know that women are 39.6% of the labour force.

What should I check before I repeat this in a briefing?

Step 3 — read what comes back, and check one thing yourself

You should get: a warning that 51.7% is a *share of a count*, not a rate; that the denominators differ; and that you need the number of women in the labour force to compute a rate. **If it does not say that, the skill did not reach it** — start a new conversation and paste again.



The stored version, and making it your own

Two more routes, and the step that matters more than either of them.

Route B — upload it as a Skill

if your plan has it

Some paid plans can store the page so you do not paste it each time.

1. **Save the skill to your device first.** On the dojo, press "Open the skill", then save the page as a file (right-click → *Save as*, or your browser's share/download menu). It is a **.md** file, which is just text.
2. In your AI tool, **look for "Skills"** — usually in settings, or in a sidebar near Projects. **The exact wording and position change from month to month**, so hunt rather than follow a screenshot.
3. **Add the file.** Give it the same name as the one at the top of the page.
4. From then on, it is available without pasting.

If you cannot find it, you have not done anything wrong. The feature may not be on your plan. **Route A does the same job.** Nothing on page 1 depends on this.

The same box, under other names

These skills are not tied to one company. The text is ordinary English and the prompts inside work the same everywhere.

Only the container has different names:

- **Claude** — Skills, or a Project's instructions
- **ChatGPT** — a Custom GPT's instructions, or a Project's instructions
- **Gemini** — a Gem's instructions

Availability changes with plan and month, so look rather than assume. The `---name: ... ---` lines at the top are harmless anywhere; delete them if you prefer.

One honest difference. The instructions transfer perfectly; the *behaviour* does not, quite. Models differ in how strictly they hold a constraint and how readily they admit uncertainty, so the same skill sometimes needs one extra line on one tool. **That is a reason to test it once on each, not a reason to stay loyal to one.**

Route C — keep it in your own file

free, and the most durable

Remember the four headings you wrote this week:

```
## What I decided
## Still open
## Sources I used
## The paragraph I paste into AI next time
```

Paste the skill under the fourth heading, above your own paragraph. Then one file carries both **what you decided** and **how you want the work done** — and it survives any change of tool, plan or company.

Paid tools remember for you. A file remembers whatever the tool is.

The step that matters most: make it yours

These three were written from one week of work in one country. **The version that will actually help you is the one carrying your own examples.** Change them.

Three small edits, in order of value

1. **Replace the example with one of your own.** A number you nearly repeated, a citation that turned out not to exist, a column your last survey did not have. Your example teaches you far better than mine.
2. **Add one line from your own field.** The check that only matters in your work — a definition your ministry uses, a rule your journal applies.
3. **Delete what you will never use.** A shorter page you actually read beats a complete one you skim.

There is no approval to seek and no version to keep in step with. It is your file now. The three on the dojo say so at the bottom: *free to copy, adapt and share.*



When it goes wrong — and writing your own

Four things that actually happen, and a template for the skill only you can write.

When it goes wrong

- **"It ignored the skill."** Usually the conversation was already long. The AI reads what is on the desk, and a long conversation buries things in the middle. **Start a new conversation and paste the skill first.**
- **"It just said Understood and stopped."** That is correct behaviour. The skill is instructions, not a question. **Give it your task next.**
- **"It gave a different answer than my colleague's."** Compare the two prompts word by word before comparing the two answers. Almost always one of you added a line.
- **"It agreed with everything I said."** The most dangerous failure, because it feels like success. Ask it directly: *"What is the strongest objection to what I just wrote?"* An assistant that never disagrees is worse than none, because it feels like approval.

Writing your own — the only one nobody else can write

The most valuable skill you will ever have is the one for **the job you do every week**. Not a clever job. A repeated one.

The template

```
---
name: what-this-is-called
description: When to reach for this - be specific about the
  situation, so you recognise it later.
---

# The title, in your own words

## When to use this
One short paragraph. The situation, not the theory.

## The steps
1. ...
2. ...
3. ...

## The prompt
#role ...
#task ...
#constraints ...
#format ...

## What to expect
What a good answer looks like - and what a wrong one looks
like, which is more useful.

## One line to keep
The sentence you want to remember in a year.
```

Write it the day after the job goes badly. That is when you know exactly what the instructions should have said — and a week later you will have forgotten.

Try one thing today

Do not read all three. Take **check-the-denominator**, paste it into a new conversation, and give it the last number you were about to repeat to somebody.

Five minutes. If nothing changes, you have lost five minutes. If something changes, you have found a habit — and the habit is the point, not the page.

